That's what we've got to deal with. That's what we're playing in. It's going to be the same for the other side. Stop fucking moaning. Support staff, sort your shit out. I want ice towels done before we get here. I want to hear us and see us practising like an England team should.' It worked, possibly because of the novelty factor of me piling into them. Everyone responded.

The human chemistry of any dressing room is delicate. There is a natural divide between bowlers and batsmen that lends itself to piss-taking. Bowlers will say, 'I wish I could bowl at you lot,' and batsmen will inform them of the pleasure they would take smashing them into the next county. I hate the word banter, but internal rivalry usually goes little further than that.

Bowlers tend to talk to one another on the field, especially when they are operating in tandem, since the era in which they were routinely hidden at fine leg between overs has gone. They are now usually found at mid-on or mid-off, close enough to share observations and strategies. Obviously, they will be unhappy if their own batsmen fail to give them the opportunity to rest by losing wickets quickly, but as long as criticism doesn't become personal, it is manageable.

Social instability is invariably magnified by sport's prominence. One of my trickiest situations as England captain came in Bangladesh in 2016. Reg Dickason, our security expert, said it was safe to tour, despite terrorist activity. I addressed a team meeting, told the lads I trusted his judgement and said we should fulfil our obligations.

There is no right and wrong in such situations. The players on the Test leg of the tour opted to follow my lead. Eoin Morgan preferred not to travel. There was no resentment at such an acutely personal choice, because, as a tightly knit group, we operated on the principle of mutual respect. Security concerns sit differently with different individuals, because external factors vary. We all have family members to consider.

My situation was complicated by Alice being in the last stages of pregnancy with our daughter Isobel. I couldn't miss a Test match, because of the strength of the views I had expressed, but flew back to England at the tail end of the one-day series. Alice was induced on 13 October, and I spent fourteen hours with Isobelle before making the return journey.

As you can imagine, I was in bits. The emotional intensity of birth stirred the most powerful of feelings, and I was lucky that I had the moral support of a friend, who coincidentally shared a connecting flight to Oman. I felt I